

Sunshine Coast Council citizen-science wedge

Concept doc, 5 May 2026. Internal. Read time ~4 min.

Sunshine Coast Council currently runs flagship citizen-science programs (Big Butterfly Count, Annual Frog Survey, and others) by manually uploading CSV files into the Atlas of Living Australia. We replace that CSV step with a branded, Co-Exist-derived mobile app that submits records natively via Darwin Core Archive (DwCA-via-BioCollect). Council gets cleaner data, their own brand on a phone-friendly volunteer flow, and zero IT lift. We get a real-revenue local-government client and a template repeatable across every other council in Australia.

1. Why this works for Council (the specific pain)

Today	With our app
Volunteers fill paper forms or spreadsheets, send them in. Coordinator chases data, reformats, manually uploads CSV to ALA BioCollect.	Volunteer opens app, taps a species, photo + GPS auto-attached, submitted live. ALA harvests via DwCA on Council's own DOI dataResource.
Big Butterfly Count: 262 records over 4 seasons (since 2022). Annual Frog Survey: 66 records over 11 seasons.	10x to 100x participation per season. Field validation prevents nonsense entries. Photo-evidence is automatic.
No real-time engagement metric for Council. No way to show ratepayers the program is working.	Live Council dashboard: records this week, top species, top spots, top volunteers. Press-release fodder, monthly.

2. What we'd build

- **Co-Exist platform tenant for SCC.** Council-branded splash, theming, content. Their logo, their language, their species lists.
- **Custom forms per program.** Big Butterfly Count form, Frog Survey form, Coastal Bird Survey form. Configurable for new programs.
- **BioCollect / DwCA integration.** Records emit as Darwin Core Archive at a stable URL. ALA harvests on schedule. Council's own DOI dataResource per program (federally citable).
- **Council dashboard.** Read-only metrics view for the Environmental Volunteer Coordinator and the comms team.

Technical premise (verified via live ALA query, 1 May 2026): Big Butterfly Count is a registered ALA dataResource (dr19044), Sunshine Coast Council is the operating institution (in665), and the existing flow is **automation=false, harvestFrequency=0**, i.e. manual CSV. We replace one substrate with another, leave the ALA registry record in place. Source draft: citizen-science-app-ecosystem-feeding-ala-2026-05-01.md.

3. Pricing

Item	Cost	Notes
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Phase 1 build (one program, branded, DwCA-emit)	\$4–8k AUD	Fits under Council discretionary budget. No formal procurement needed.
Hosting + maintenance retainer	\$200/mo	\$2,400/yr recurring. Minor edits, security, ALA-pipeline monitoring.
Additional programs (Frog Survey, Coastal Bird Survey, etc)	\$1.5–3k each	Same template, configured for the new program.

4. Who at Council

- **Primary contact:** Environmental Volunteer Coordinator, evc@sunshinecoast.qld.gov.au. This is the published contact for the Big Butterfly Count and the Frog Survey. They are the gateway.
- **Decision authority:** EVC plus Environment & Sustainability Manager. Discretionary budget at this size sits with the manager, not procurement.
- **Open question:** the EVC's personal name is not yet verified. To pin before any contact lands.

5. The mechanism: demo-first, in-person, NOT cold email

Cold email to evc@sunshinecoast.qld.gov.au is the wrong move. It lands as one of fifty grant pitches and goes to triage. The right move is **demo-first at a Council ecosystem event**:

1. Tate attends a Council-organised volunteer or environment forum (Maleny, Caloundra, Mooloolaba) with the Co-Exist app live on his phone.
2. Conversational opener with the EVC or program coordinator on site: "I'm local. I built this. Watch." Submit a record live.
3. Follow-up next morning with a one-page leave-behind PDF and a 15-minute demo offer.

Tate's natural Sunshine Coast presence is the unfair advantage here. No competitor pitching a council from Sydney or Melbourne can match an in-person Saturday-morning demo at a local volunteer event.

6. Why this client first (and why it scales)

- **Local + Tate physical access.** Walk-in distance, not phone distance.
- **Smaller deal but unblocks the council-tier business model.** \$4–8k is below what a serious procurement gate would scrutinise. We get in, we ship, we get a reference.
- **Replicable.** Every council in Australia (537 of them) runs analogous citizen-science programs. SCC reference + the DwCA template is a sales asset for every next council pitch. Logan, Brisbane City, Noosa, Gympie, Moreton Bay are obvious next-five.
- **Ties into the wider Ecodia thesis.** Co-Exist already collects geolocated youth-engagement data. Adding DwCA-emit makes every Co-Exist deployment an ALA-recognised dataResource with its own DOI. Massive credibility infrastructure for biodiversity-credit and Landcare-adjacent peak-body pitches downstream.

7. Risks (named)

- **Council procurement is slow by default.** Three to six months from intro to PO is normal. Mitigant: pitch as "pilot under existing discretionary budget", not capex. Stay under the threshold that triggers procurement review.

- **Grant cycle lock-in.** If the program is grant-funded, the funding window may not align with our delivery. Mitigant: ask the EVC about funding source on first contact. Time the pilot launch to their next grant round if needed.
- **iNaturalist is “good enough” for some councils.** Counter: iNat is generalist, not branded, no Council dashboard, no campaign lock-in, no DOI per program. We are the Council's own data substrate, not a tenant inside someone else's.

The ask of Tate

Confirm or redirect. If yes:

1. Tate identifies the next Council ecosystem event he can attend with Co-Exist live on his phone (volunteer event, Mary Cairncross open day, environment forum, similar).
2. Conductor preps a 5-minute live demo flow on a SCC-branded test tenant of Co-Exist + a one-page leave-behind PDF.
3. Tate runs the in-person opener at the event. Conductor handles follow-up correspondence the morning after, on Tate's explicit go-ahead per the no-client-contact rule.